

5 Scholastic Psychology: The Authority of Aristotle

Portraits of imperial epochs such as those of the pharaohs, of Alexander, and of the caesars can be painted with relatively broad strokes. Empires are regulated by a set of laws. They are governed by a visible coterie of powerful figures. They possess that unmistakably imperial tone of life. Their economies are based on a specific currency and depend on a few basic goods. They have rather transparent policies toward neighbors and rather well-articulated strategies for defense and conquest. They speak in one tongue that must be mastered by all who would share in the bounty and protections of citizenship. Portraits of "empire," then, are geometric. No matter how great the particular empire, one always knows how much canvas is required to contain it. On the few occasions when an empire succeeds, it becomes the focus of an age. That is, its entire culture becomes its principal export, and this culture is of such a nature as to transform and dominate alternative cultures. The empire that succeeds best and thereby creates a historically identifiable age is one that places a durable mark on every feature of social life. Accordingly, when the empire fails, nothing that defined it remains unchanged. Art, law, letters, economy, homelife, religion, politics, all display the signs of change as that which once animated each of them begins its decline. The historian's problem, in studying that almost fantastic period represented by the deceiving title "medieval," is that it is a post-imperial period, one occurring at the end of an empire that was great even by inflated imperial standards.

The problem, then, is not that the medieval epoch lacks distinguishing features but that each of its features is a feature-in-transition. As it is post-imperial, the medieval epoch is also pre-national. Indeed, the nations of Europe as received by modern times were medieval inventions. Empires have an imperial character and nations a national character. But what is the "character of a transition" if not a contradiction? It is only after we appreciate the complexity of this question that we can be protected against those misleading common-

places employed in describing and dismissing the "Middle" Ages. According to these commonplaces, the period from Rome's conquest to the Renaissance was filled with a tame and dull homogenization of thought and belief; with a feudal system that reduced the faithful to servility; and with political, moral, and intellectual hegemony exercised by a clerical elite in league with dukes and princes.

With respect to the putative homogenization of thought and belief, it is only necessary to point to the difficulty of writing medieval history to expose the error. It is far easier to describe that which was Hellenic or Roman than to summarize that which was distinctively medieval. Indeed, it is precisely because the medieval epoch was neither imperial nor national that the search for its character must be so laborious. Thought and belief, always ambiguous terms when applied to more than one person, were probably more heterogeneous from the sixth to the eleventh centuries than during any equivalent span before or since. That superstition was rampant is beyond question, but this superstition, as a non-rational phenomenon, is a veritable symbol of heterogeneity of outlooks. That is, in order to render belief uniform, it is necessary to reduce it to a set of teachable principles, to put it on a rational and even quasi-philosophical level, and to argue it into an apparently unimpeachable form. Formal religions take hold only after dislodging the superstitious mind. They replace superstition. In this respect, we cannot even discuss Catholicism as the orthodox and dominant belief of the period until well into the eleventh century, and we must date its intellectual hegemony in the thirteenth.

The demise of a recognizably *Roman* world was brought about by internal corruptions and external force, the latter applied by waves of tribes from Gallic and Germanic Europe. These people had their own venerable customs and laws, most of them radically different from Rome's. The Salic laws were usually no more than a set of simple sentences indicating the penalty for specific infractions. Twelve solidi in the currency of the age was the amount it would cost to buy a slave, so we begin to see the importance attached to various persons and actions by noting the cash-penalties assessed: 200 solidi for killing a female child, 600 for killing a woman of childbearing age, 900 if she was pregnant. The same laws assessed fines of various amounts for touching different parts of the body of an unmarried woman, or for destroying various portions of an adversary's anatomy: a greater fine for the loss of an eye than a finger, etc. Needless to say, by the refined and developed standards of Roman law, all this was no more than a form of barter.

As for the feudal system, it was in fact a variety of systems evolving continuously over a period of centuries. It was never merely an alternative to anarchy and the daily threat of a violent death; it was typically the only alternative. As an essentially economic system, feudalism had much in common with Roman life from the second to the fifth centuries; that is, the feudal lord or

baron was the economic equivalent of the Roman governor or provincial. But what was behind the system was a privatization of life and property quite unlike anything seen in classical Rome or Greece. Conquering hordes had lent their strength to leaders who promised the booty of victory and who enjoyed loyalty as long as their own personal strength and the success of their assaults continued. From the very outset, then, the conquest of Rome had private interests as an essential motive. These interests evolved into Feudal lordships, bounded properties, and small armies of laboring vassals who in simpler times might have been slaves.

As a system of classes, feudalism gave the lord or baron a position quite akin to that of chieftain in prefeudal tribal communities. Scarcity requires economy, and economy requires binding agreements which, in turn, demand authority. Whether this authority is vested in archons, consuls, chieftains, barons, or kings depends principally upon the size of the community and its historic sources. Contemporary Americans must be willing to sacrifice their lives in the national defense, an obligation quite in line with the serf's. The same Americans have a servile relationship to laws, including those that tax possessions, proscribe treason, and otherwise regulate public conduct.

Of course, American citizens share in the authorship of these laws and their amendment. But feudal life was also based on agreements by both parties, and these agreements had the force of law.¹ The serf entered into service through a ritual that included physical contact with his lord. Behind the symbolism stood the belief that something actually passed from the latter to the former; a form of sanctuary, an oath of protection having nearly corporeal properties. R. W. Southern, in *The Making of the Middle Ages*, recounts submission by one freeman for the purpose of gaining another vineyard. As Professor Southern notes in his analysis of the documents of the period, servitude was considered the lot of every man, if only servitude to God. Thus, some men were "serfs to the serfs of God," finding in their servility only the proper conduct of a Christian, since "all men labour and serve, and the serf is a freeman of the Lord, and the freeman is a serf of Christ."² Note also that the same Greeks who reviled tyranny benefited from slavery. Plato's men of gold, brass, silver, and iron are models for those hierarchic classifications of citizens that until modern times suffused every political community of the Western world. The slave in Greece was the one whose side lost the battle, whose birth was non-Hellenic, and whose debts could not be paid in any other way. The advent of the Dominate in the Roman Empire introduced to the Western community the precedent of man-as-god and, therefore citizen-as-servant. This is all worth considering not in order to absolve medievalism of wrongful deeds—if, in fact, it is a function of posterity to absolve its ancestry of anything—but to prevent the needs in question from being judged unique to a given age or religious temperament.

These generalizations, however, have limited validity when considering so

various and evolving an epoch. It is only in the High Middle Ages (from, say, 1100 to 1350) that we can find written justifications for the policies and arrangements that applied to a substantial fraction of the Western world. Only at these later dates is the term "medieval" supported by those documented and reflective elements necessary for more precise historical analysis. From 500 to 1000 A.D., we can examine certain people, even certain groups. But we are not able to add these diverse settlements together to arrive at the character of an entire age, let alone its psychological attitudes. We can only try to capture, in a series of snapshots, how the mind of the Middle Ages grappled with itself and with the awesomely unpredictable world around it.

Fear and Magic

The changes that overtook the West between the fifth and tenth centuries were colossal by standards both ancient and modern. There is so little in common between the Frankish kingdom of Charlemagne and the late empire of Justinian that even comparisons are difficult to establish. Of all the prevailing forces working to change the world, none was more significant than Islam. The transformations imposed by the disciples of Mahomet (571–632) were progressive, cumulative, and overwhelming. Successively, Mohammedanism overcame Persia (651), Syria (636), Egypt (642), north Africa (698), and Spain (711), and even led to the blockade of Constantinople (717). The resulting economic and cultural consequences arose most immediately from the fact that the Mediterranean itself no longer served Western interests. The searching thesis that the Middle Ages are to be understood principally in terms of Islamic control of the Mediterranean Sea was advanced long ago by Professor Henri Pirenne.³ His own description of what had occurred cannot be improved:

The familiar and almost "family" sea which once united all the parts of this commonwealth was to become a barrier between them. On all its shores, for centuries, social life, in its fundamental characteristics, had been the same; religion the same; customs and ideas, the same or very nearly so. . . . But now, all of a sudden, the very lands where civilization had been born were torn away; the Cult of the Prophet was substituted for the Christian Faith, Moslem law for Roman law, and Arab tongue for the Greek and the Latin tongue. The Mediterranean had been a Roman lake; it now became, for the most part, a Moslem lake. From this time on it separated, instead of uniting, the East and the West of Europe. The tie was broken. . . .⁴

The part of the world which we now identify as Europe had become enclosed. To the north, the Danes and Saxons presented a constant threat to the vestiges of Roman civilization. From Spain in the south, the invasion and pi-

racy of the Saracens were irresistible. In the East, of course, Islam was supreme. That life, which once had been Mediterranean, now collapsed toward a safe European Center, but it could not be moved northward intact. Instead, it degenerated into that form of tribalism which would evolve into feudalism. Even the secondary effects of the Mohammedan conquest were telling. Syria, for example, had been the major source of papyrus, and from 650 until the eleventh century the supply was virtually eliminated. The Arabic number system, which would animate European science and mathematics only after the fourteenth century, remained isolated from the Western mind.

Technology is the achievement of a settled people. It arises when an abiding problem, an abiding conflict with nature, insists on a solution: for example, the Egyptian farmer's need for water and the need to protect crops from an overflowing Nile; the Athenian desire to erect a temple with massive columns. Technological undertakings on a grand scale are pointless to those living a nomadic life. By the time the problem is solved, conditions have forced the nomad to a new but ever temporary home. Thus the threat and the reality of invasion, of piracy, and of crop failures not only robbed Europeans of their culture but denied them the very geographic permanence that might make a new culture possible.

Time itself was, for the medieval mind, far less metrical than it is to the modern mind. Indeed, the medieval sense of time was as exceptional as so many of the practices and beliefs we have come to identify with the entire epoch. For the medieval Christian, time had two major divisions: the brief and insignificant one in which one's sinful life proceeded, and the cosmically enduring one in which the suffering or the joys of the soul would occur. Thus:

Every day, every hour, thus without ceasing
I must finish my life, and recommence
In this death uselessly alive.⁵

Christian belief and its essential elements of baptism, death, and resurrection fostered a perception of time devoid of scientific meaning and one not seen in philosophy since the age of the pre-Socratics. Each day was a kind of rebirth unconnected by that cognitive thread we know as history. Medieval life passed in a series of otherwise disconnected moments. Its events were sudden, as sudden as the imminent apocalypse that would end all life all time, all fear. Marc Bloch put it aptly:

These men, subjected both externally and internally to so many ungovernable forces, lived in a world in which the passage of time escaped their grasp all the more because they were so ill-equipped to measure it. . . . The truth is that the regard for accuracy remained profoundly alien to the minds even of the leading men of that age.⁶

Without a sense of time, a sense reinforced and validated by empirical regularities, the concept of natural causes fails to overtake the unharnessed imagination. The medieval mind, this mind without a clock, was scientifically backward. In any case, neither humans nor the world was to survive very long. The end would come in the twinkling of an eye. What sign would there be?—Who would be so bold as to reckon the moment God's will would assert itself? "What is man?" asked Alcuin, the resident scholar in the court of Charlemagne. And he answers, "The slave of death, a passing wayfarer." And then, "How is man placed? Like a lantern in the wind."⁷ These are lines provided by a man who described himself thus: "Alcuin was my name: Learning I loved. Oh thou that redest this pray for my soul."⁸ The men and women who lived in this period endured the harshest circumstances. The power of the Church was political, but neither its moral nor its religious lessons could penetrate that large and shifting body of tribes that remained trapped by the timeless rites and visions of the pagan. With gruesome weariness these men and women struggled to rationalize the effects of their woeful lives. Not only was death a release, but the decaying body of the dead parent was praised for its sweet smell. The soul of this body now enjoying the presence of God Himself may still come back to sanctify its former shell. Thus a lock of hair, a rotting bone, the bristle of a beard, may have the power to heal or to protect its possessor against the devil and his demons. In one immense though bounded universe, man and his planet, the stars, the moon, each blade of grass, all shared in God's all-seeing vision. As late as the thirteenth century, St. Francis would repeat this spirit of medieval life in words whose beauty has survived the tragedy of it all:

Praised be my Lord for brother wind
 And for the air and clouds and fair and every
 kind of weather.
 Praised be my Lord for sister water.
 Praised be my Lord for our sister, mother earth,
 The which sustains and keeps us
 And brings forth diverse fruits with grass and
 flowers bright.
 Praised be my Lord for our sister, the bodily death.
 For the second death shall do them no ill.⁹

It would be misleading to reserve to the Middle Ages the mind's domination by fear and magic, for every period of the human experience finds good sense in short supply. There can be no doubt but that the pervasive fear of death did have a paralyzing effect upon the few who might have made lasting contributions of an artistic or intellectual nature. Scripture was interpreted as predicting the world's end in 1000 A.D. or thereabouts, and to those who believed this (such credulity remains in abundant supply) the notion of launching a major project of any sort would have seemed chimerical. Even for those who were

unaware of the exact date of the apocalypse or who entertained a different date, the crucial fact was that there was some date and that not too distant. That a fear of the end, both a personal and a worldly end, was generally held seems confirmed by the incessant rationalizations invented to control it. Death as freedom, as liberation, as rebirth, as escape, even *death as a good* are the themes that abound in the literary evidence of the period.

The run of competent and occasionally great philosophers in the West begins with St. Anselm (1033–1109). We are tempted to connect this resumption of intellectual pursuits with a fact that must have surprised a good many Christians; the fact that they were still alive after 1000 A.D.! There were, of course, less airy considerations responsible for the reawakening, and we shall examine several of them. Nevertheless we are advised not to dismiss too eagerly what, to the modern mind seems utterly incomprehensible: that scholarship, art, enduring institutions, and culture itself suffered neglect by a people generally persuaded that the world would not endure.

Accepting this, however, we must be careful not to judge these people and their other characteristics in terms foreign to the rest of the story of civilization. If we are to segregate the Middle Ages on any basis that might satisfy the demand for rigor, we must avoid variables such as poverty, plague, fear, superstition, zealotry, faith, and the like. We find these generously represented throughout the course of history. What is different, however, is the ease with which the literate and even intellectually gifted medieval citizen abandoned so completely those critical faculties that are the stamp of a tutored mind. What was unique about the Middle Ages, then, was not the record compiled by the struggling masses but the record attained by those very figures who presumed to lead, and by those who might pass for the best minds. In this respect, the achievements by scholars between Boethius (480–524), who was the last of the great classical thinkers, and John the Scot (ca. 810–ca. 877) were negligible. This interval, coinciding with the expansion of Islam and the scattering of the Western community, may be described legitimately as a “dark age.” It may, however, also be viewed as a period of regrouping and assimilation during which monks in the west of Ireland preserved the language of the Hellenes; when kings and popes sought economic and even cultural foundations for peaceful coexistence; when the teachings of Islam forced the philosophically inclined believer to articulate arguments for Christianity. It was also the period in which Arab and Jewish scholars could reflect upon the ancient wisdom of Greece and Rome and thereby begin to invigorate the growing empire intellectually.

Charlemagne and the Prelude to Renewal

When Charlemagne allowed himself to be crowned by the pope, he displayed the rare talent of the political genius who knows what the future will demand.

More than any religious connotation that might have attached to the event, the coronation symbolized the rebirth of the Western world, a world now organized around a set of religious principles shared by both the temporal and the spiritual monarchs of that world. The result was at least the possibility of European unification against an enemy who, now, was a heretic as well. The Western king could now claim to defend a competing truth and one as great in its implications as that which impelled the soldiers of Islam.

We would overestimate Charlemagne's personal contribution to credit him with the creation of a European community of nations. But his alliance with the Church of Rome did establish at least a sense of community in a part of the world which, for several hundred years, was marked by provincialism. He served as king of the Franks for thirty-two years (768–800) and, until his death (814), as Charles I, emperor of the Holy Roman Empire.¹⁰ He was devoted to learning and committed to the education of his people. He imported Alcuin from England to establish a palace school and strongly encouraged the bishops of the empire to incorporate schools within the churches and abbeys. These schools and even the curriculum introduced by Alcuin¹¹ were the wellsprings of the medieval university, an invention of the twelfth century. He was no Pericles, nor was Alcuin an Anaxagoras, but Charlemagne did restore respectability to learning and thus cut a seam in the heavy curtain that had darkened European scholarship for four hundred years. He restored some stability to the economy, provided at least the hint of safety for those who might otherwise have wandered, and planted the banner of Christianity in every major center of Europe from the Ebro River in Spain to the southern edge of Denmark. To the extent that the modern Western world retains institutions, ideas, and a general perspective that are Greco-Roman in their broadest features, then, to that extent, Charlemagne can be said to have been a maker of the modern Western world. He did not eliminate fear or magic—though he legislated against both—but he created a climate congenial to their antagonist, reason.

The Revival of (Aristotelian) Rationalism

There was a twelfth-century Renaissance which, in purely intellectual respects, compared favorably with its more vaunted successor in the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries.¹² The most vivid signs of this general rekindling of energy and hope are, of course, the majestic Gothic cathedrals. Even today, in an age that has made bigness a virtue, these churches seem to be and are of gigantic proportion. Still more impressive is the fact that nearly all of them (at Paris, Chartres, Amiens, Laon, Beauvais, Rheims, LeMans, Tour, Orleans, Mt. St. Michel, at Canterbury and Oxford, at Prague and Cologne, and throughout Europe and the British Isles) appeared in less than two hundred years. Coincident with their appearance were the revival of classical Latin, the resumption of

serious philosophical inquiry, and, most significantly of all to intellectual history, the passage from Saracen Spain to Christian Europe of the Arabic translations of Aristotle's works.

The major figure here must be *Avicenna* (980–1037), whose Islamic rendition of Aristotelian thought would reacquaint the Western philosophical community with a far wider range of Aristotle's work than had been available in the west for centuries. His commentaries on Aristotle came to pose any number of questions for the thirteenth-century Christian theologians. Consider only Aristotle's metaphysical arguments for the eternity of the world—arguments directly contradicting Genesis and obviating the need for the God of Christianity. Consider, too, Aristotle's entire ethical system in which the concept of sin plays no part and according to which the ultimate sanctions of morality are grounded in considerations of the here and now.

Avicenna was a physician and a prolific commentator on the scientific and philosophical works of Aristotle. He anticipated such vexing psychological issues as our awareness of our selves as continuing entities, even amidst bodily changes. He explained the sense of "self" as something immediately known by a thinking thing (the *res cogitans* Descartes will offer six centuries later) independently of any and all experience. His hypothetical "flying man," suspended in space and blindfolded, retains a vivid awareness of his very *self* even while shielded from all external stimuli. Thus is self-knowledge based upon the very cognitive nature of a rational being.

It is in the Sixth Treatise of his *Deliverance* that he develops his psychological theories more fully along Aristotelian lines, but with a robust infusion of Platonic theory as well. In Chapter IX of this work he argues that the basis of all rational concepts must be immaterial, for such abstractions cannot be materially represented and thus cannot enter into causal relations with the material senses. The senses respond to the particulars of stimulation (*this tree*), but the rational faculty is able to abstract from this the *intelligible form* of "tree" and thus form a universal concept. By the same token, this immaterial grounding of rationality points to an immaterial soul which is therefore saved from degenerative changes. The soul is immortal.

First slowly and haltingly but soon quickly and continuously, the authority of Aristotle challenged and overtook the traditional authority of neo-Platonism. St. Anselm (1033–1109), who may be said to have initiated the philosophic revival in the West, titled his major work *Faith Seeking Understanding*, and argued patiently for the role of perception and reason in Christian life. His principal authority, however, is St. Augustine. Next, we confront the *Four Books of Sentences* of Peter Lombard (1100–ca. 1164), the most influential work in religious philosophy of the time and one that proclaims even more forcefully the position of reason in the affairs of faith. Still, the authority remains Augustine, who directs us to find God with that quality of ours, "than

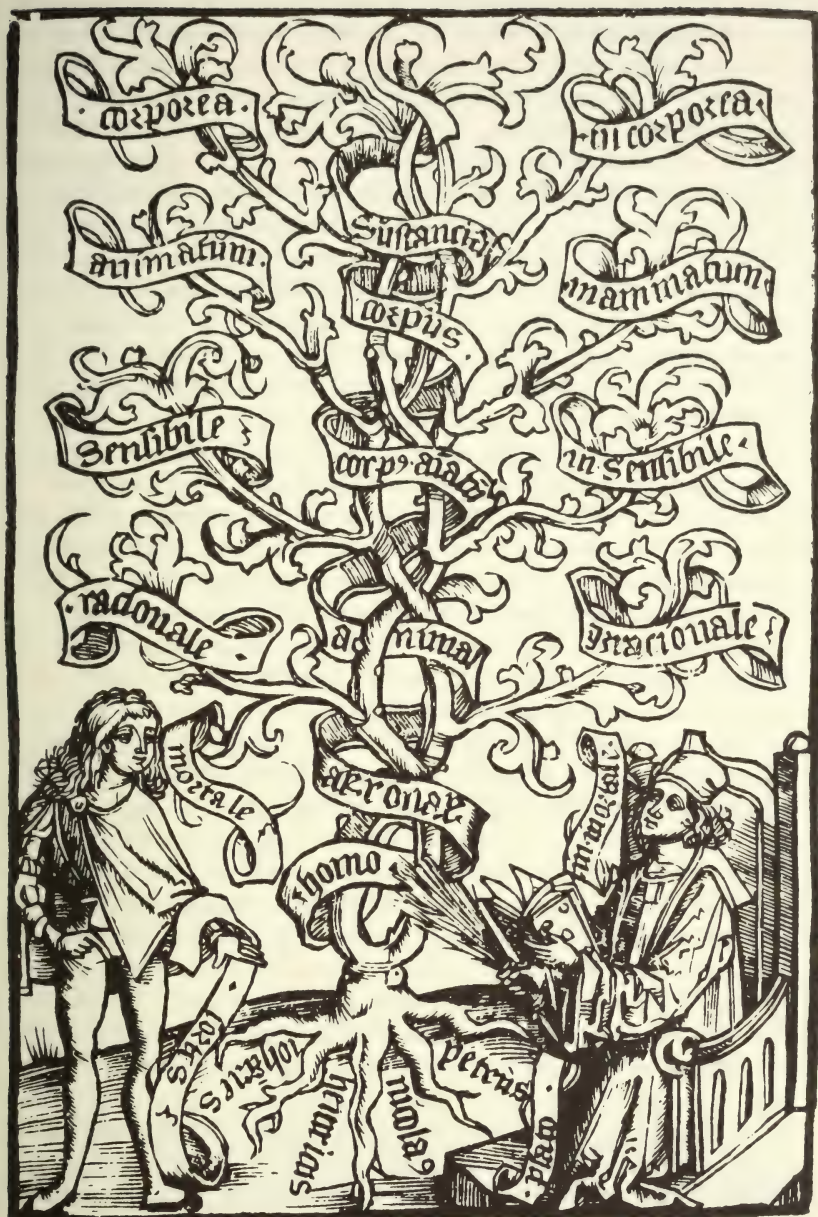
which our nature has not better, which is the mind.”¹³ But at the same time we discover Peter Abailard (1079–1142) placing the greatest emphasis on the authority of Aristotle, whom he calls “our prince” and who, for the next two centuries will be reverentially and simply dubbed “the Philosopher.”

The revival of rationalism cannot be reduced to a single or even small set of causative agents. Nor is this the place to identify the many factors involved. Charlemagne’s contribution has been noted, a contribution sustained and reinforced by King Otto, whose German kingdom enjoyed a mini-renaissance in the tenth century. St. Peter’s, which had been assaulted by the Saracens as recently as 846, now commanded the brave loyalty of all of Christian Europe, and the Roman Church was able to administer more effectively the efforts of her monks and missionaries. Rome itself was now secure enough to serve as a center for grammar and law as the empire sought to restore its classical character. Not only was the empire secure against Islam, it was even able to reclaim territories previously lost. By 1085 the recovery of Spain had proceeded as far as Toledo, and by 1118 it included Saragossa. The notorious First Crusade (1096) was, we must note, a mere expression of the revival and not an antecedent.¹⁴

By the end of the twelfth century we find Europe in a state somewhat similar to that of Athens under Alexander: war, plague, and discord giving way to order, security, and growing prosperity; political instability submitting to the will of the great leader; and a visible but now conquerable foe providing the stimulus to cohesion. The nightmare had ended, men and women and the world itself were still in one piece, and the future, if only because there was a future, seemed far brighter.

Scholastic Psychology

In *The World of Medieval Learning*, Anders Pilz reproduces and discusses a quite remarkable illustration taken from a work by Peter of Spain published in 1514. Although the publication falls well within the period of the Italian Renaissance, the illustration is quintessentially medieval. As Anders Pilz says, it is the one illustration “that can sum up the referential system of the medieval scholar.”¹⁵ It is “Porphyry’s Tree.” Here Socrates (expressed in the diminutive “Sortes”) and Plato are sketched at the base of the tree, with Socrates standing and Plato in a chair. Between them as the very roots of the tree are the names of particular persons (Henricus, Petrus, et al.) who, as individuals, fall outside any classification. It is only a genus or species that can be classified, not any detached item, including a specific person. But these particulars arise from the species *homo*, that universal class of which all individual persons are members. Combined with nonhuman creatures, *homo* arises from the larger class *animal*, of which there are categories of the *rational* and the *irrational*. These in turn



Porphyry's Tree

are derived from the more basic category of the *corpus animatum*, or *living body* which may be endowed with sense (*sensible*) and thus qualify as *animal*, or be without sense (*insensible*) and thus be *plant*. Ever more basic is the category of *substance* (*substantia*) formed by the most fundamental of all ontological distinctions, that between the *material* (*corporea*) and the *immaterial* (*incorporea*). To turn the tree upside down is to trace the ontological pedigree that culminates in identifiable and particular persons. The tree culminates in the universal class *substantia* into which everything having real existence falls. This entire apparatus is forged from Aristotle's (ten) categories. The most fundamental disputes of the medieval period pertained to the nature of the universals, their ontological standing, and the role of mental processes either in comprehending them or being their very source. Porphyry's tree continues to be a useful framework within which to comprehend the issues and theories spawned by Scholastic psychology.

Among those who write general histories of Western thought, there is a tendency to reduce the works of Augustine to "neo-Platonism" and to reduce the works of Thomas Aquinas to "Aristotelianism." The respect in which this practice is arguably valid is, alas, the respect in which we might reduce *all* philosophy either to Platonism or Aristotelianism. It is true that Thomas Aquinas (1225–1274) has been the intellectual voice of the Roman Church since the fifteenth century, and it is also true that his two major works, the *Summa Theologiae* and the *Summa Contra Gentiles*, derive their inspiration from Aristotle. But derivation is not duplication. One could not reconstruct Thomistic thought merely from a knowledge of Aristotelian thought. The two philosophers undertook their works in vastly different intellectual climates, with vastly different orientations and with vastly different objectives. If we are to comprehend the medieval view of psychological man, we must focus on Thomistic psychology. Thomas Aquinas was not the only or even the most influential figure to raise the important questions, but his were the only works that included all the perspectives prevailing in his age. And if we are to comprehend the portion that is distinctly psychological, we must first appreciate the problems facing Thomas and his Church in the thirteenth century. Let us, then, review briefly the problems confronting Thomas Aquinas in regard to human psychology and then proceed to his essentially Aristotelian solutions.

1. *Can man know God?* This is the central epistemological problem of the High Middle Ages. Peter Abailard, in his *Sic et Non* ("Yes and No"), listed some 158 theological questions that had been answered in a contradictory way by Scripture and by the early Christian Fathers. He was also one of several influential twelfth-century spokesmen to reject the real existence of universals and to adopt nominalism: that is, to assert that only individual entities are real

and that so-called universals are merely class-names (*nomines*) referring to concepts in the mind. By the time of Aquinas' floruit, there was a creeping skepticism toward doctrine, a growing demand for rational as opposed to scriptural authority. The question of whether or not man can know God, then, was just the most pressing member of the larger set, *Can man know anything?*

2. *What are our duties to God?* This question assumes that the general epistemological question has been answered; that is, we know what man can know of God and God's will. Now what remains to be determined is man's obligation to self, to the State, to his fellow man. *→ knowing duty to self*
3. *What is sin?* In the ninth century, the Church was so disorganized that the pope was unable to provide Charlemagne with an official liturgy for the celebration of the Mass. By the thirteenth century, intense efforts were directed at rendering Christian practices uniform. The Holy Roman Empire was indeed an empire, requiring laws, agreements, and an understandable set of first principles. The historic civil law of Rome, again taken to be the law of nations (the *ius gentium*), was revived in the centers of legal scholarship and incorporated into the decisions of royal and ecclesiastical courts. But this had to be reconciled with a body of belief far more detailed than the belief existing at the time of Justinian. Secular and clerical powers were now so intermingled that the citizen-believer desperately needed guidance for a lawful and Christian life. The concept of sin had to be refined in such a way that all kings, bishops, and farmers alike could be made aware of the specific obligations they had to their Creator.
4. *What is the nature and status of the human will?* Scripture had granted freedom of the will while insisting that God caused all things. In the previous chapter we reviewed the Augustinian resolution of this apparent conflict, a resolution not complete enough for the more enlightened and critical minds of the thirteenth century.
5. *What is the right form of life for man?* Certain interpretations of the classical works tended toward the conclusion that the soul dies with the body. Thomas Aquinas needed to fashion an explanation of the soul's mission, and it needed to be one that would not be caught in the logical traps set by such Islamic authorities as Averroes (1126–1198) ("The Commentator"), whose commentaries on Aristotle reached unwanted antirealist and even materialistic conclusions regarding the essence of mind and thought. Averroist disciples in the West (e.g., Siger of Brabant, ca. 1240–1284) were tempted by the

Averroist position that the soul perishes with the body, since it is the soul that grants individual (personal) identity and since that which is individual is, necessarily, destructible. Only abstract reason (*nous*) survives, and this is the same in all people. Thus, personal survival is impossible.

Many other questions were taken up by Thomas Aquinas, including others as fundamental to theology as these were. However, we need explore only his treatment of these to outline his broad perspective on human psychology. We might begin this outline with an observation by Maurice de Wulf on Scholastic psychology in general:

According to the medieval classification of the sciences, psychology is merely a chapter of special physics, although the most important chapter; for man is a microcosm; he is the central figure of the universe.¹⁶

Until the thirteenth century, the medieval view of human nature was essentially Augustinian, which is to say Platonistic in its most defined features. The Holy Trinity served as a metaphor of human consciousness viewed, accordingly, as the trinity of sense, reason, and intellect. Each of these faculties was able to provide knowledge of a certain sort, but only the last (*nous, intellectus*) could discern truth itself.

As early as the ninth century, John Scotus Eriugena could offer a more or less complete system of psychology by combining Platonic idealism with the tenets of Christian faith. In his *De Divisione Naturae*,¹⁷ a work that is astonishing given the sorry intellectual climate surrounding its authorship, he reaffirms the Platonic distinction between attribute (*accidens*) and essence (*substantia*) and argues that the senses can apprehend only the former. That is, the senses as material agencies can be affected only by the material aspects of the world. These, because they are of an ephemeral and crude sort, have little direct connection with the ultimate and sublime reality of God. So far, this is orthodox Platonist teaching. Through the gift of reason (*logos, ratio*) the perceiver is able to assimilate these crude physical facts in such a way as to comprehend the supra-factual order and design of the universe. Even this higher degree of cognitive power is limited, however, because the universal order so disclosed is only an order among things; it is an ordering of effects but not an awareness of their true, nonphysical causes. It is only when the passive senses and the active reason deposit their contents into that spiritual realm of intellect that the fundamental truth of nature can be discerned. Since these truths are above and before things, and since they are, alas, ideas, that which discovers them must, itself, be immaterial. As for human beings, they, too, are a kind of intellectual idea held eternally in the mind of God.

A distinguishing feature of the philosophical revival that took place in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries is the rejection of such extreme idealism. John Scotus Eriugena rejected the facts of sensation as reaching basic truths and thereby spoke in defense of an idealism that could never advance beyond the point at which Plato left it. The Scholastic philosophers, though never abandoning the spirit of idealism, were willing to deal with the perceptible realities of nature as facts and as facts that expressed truths. We discover this willingness in St. Anselm's *Dialogus de Veritate*, which credits the senses with an accurate reflection of the facts of nature while condemning the "interior sense" for deceiving itself by creating false opinions about sensation.¹⁸ For Anselm, truth finally is perceived by the mind alone but, in this act of creative perception, the mind makes use of the accurate neutrality of the senses. It is this line of reasoning that led him to his celebrated *Ontological Argument*¹⁹ for the existence of God. We need not analyze this complex and vexing thesis, but we might note its psychological orientation. Anselm advanced the theory that what the mind is capable of entertaining is, by that fact, real. In order for the mind to be impressed with an idea, it must enjoy a faculty that is compatible with that which might impress it. For example, if we are able to see color, it is not only because there is color but because nature had equipped the human faculties to be responsive to this feature of the world. A faculty does not exist for which there is no corresponding item or process in nature. Now, the mind, as an enlarged faculty, is able to comprehend "that than which there can be nothing greater" and this, finally, is God. Since we are able to comprehend the possibility of that "than which there can be nothing greater," the possibility must refer to what exists in reality.

The ontological argument is neither trivial nor "subjective" in the prosaic sense. God's existence on this account is not based simply on the fact that someone might conceive of it. Nor does the argument require, as some have suspected, that an island "than which none can be greater" exists because we conceive of one. First, there cannot be an island than which none can be greater because such an island would be the universe or would be infinite and, therefore, would not be an island. We can, according to the argument, have the conception only if the capacity for the conception were imposed upon our understanding. But, to be imposed, an agency commensurate with the conception itself must exist. This at least, is the first step in approaching the subtle complexity of the ontological argument.

Anselm was not proposing to replace faith with reason, nor was he suggesting that God's existence in any way depended on the idea one might have of it. He was not advancing a Platonic idealism either. Instead, and with the influence of a great and revered teacher, he was permitting faith to rest upon a rational foundation such that mind and spirit need not battle any longer. It remained only for Peter Lombard's best-selling *Four Books of Sentences* to persuade the

medieval faithful that God is known in his works, known through an intellect informed by perception. With this final spadework accomplished, the thirteenth century was able to host that grand synthesis of thought stretching back to Plato and Aristotle and, along the way, include Augustine, Boethius, John Scotus, Anselm, and Peter Lombard, in the synthesis that is Thomistic Scholasticism.

Although the ideas and theories comprising Scholastic thought are varied in both tone and origin, the synthesis itself can be attributed to two men, Albertus Magnus and his pupil, Thomas Aquinas. It is the latter's writings that present the Scholastic approach, indeed the Scholastic solutions to the problems bequeathed by ancient philosophers, problems that had to be solved in a manner compatible with what were taken to be the truths of the Christian religion. The approach to the problem of knowledge is illustrative.

Consistent with Aristotle, Scholastic psychology distinguishes between the factual knowledge of the senses, a knowledge that the sensory powers of animals can provide, and that knowledge of principles that only reason can embrace. Thus, although experience can inform about things, it cannot provide us with a knowledge of laws. Put in another and more classical way, experience is and must be of particulars only, whereas reason comprehends the universals. It is from the particulars of sense that reason abstracts the universals. Reason is a faculty of the soul. In fact, the soul itself is an intellectual principle.²⁰ As with Avicenna, the Scholastics discover in Aristotle grounds on which to deny the corruptibility of the soul.²¹

Animals, allegedly lacking the intellectual principle, survive by instinctual patterns of responding. Human beings, through reason, apprehend universals, and this allows them to fashion an infinite variety of solutions to all sorts of problems. They are not limited to perceptual data in reaching judgments, nor are they driven to accept natural phenomena instinctively.²²

Against Plato, the Scholastic system admits not only the true and factual status of sensations but also places importance on the physiological mechanisms by which the senses inform the intellect.²³ On the occasion of physical death, the nutritive and sensitive faculties of the soul cease, for these require a body for their expression. But the will and the intellect survive.²⁴

Still in the patrimony of Aristotle, medieval psychologists distinguished between different species of intellect. There is first that power of the soul by which thought is possible, called "potential intellect." Operating on the actual perceived facts of the world, the potential intellect gives way to the "actual intellect." By reflecting on its own operations and contents, the soul functions as an "acquired intellect," one that comes about only when the mind has been supplied with data and with reflective powers. Behind these operations must be some causal power that drives the actual and acquired intellects, and this is what the Scholastics referred to as the "agent-intellect" (*agens intellectus*). By way of the agent-intellect, what was only in potentiality becomes realized. It is the actual intellect that abstracts the form of a thing from its appearance. The

senses can embrace only the attributes, but the intellect can discern the form.²⁵ Now this is not a Platonic process: that is, the form is surely not the idea by which the thing comes about. Rather, the form is in the matter as a principle, but the senses can respond only to the matter and not to the principle. Thus what we come to know is not what the senses have responded to, for knowledge is an abstraction. It is based on principles of matter, but the principles themselves are of course immaterial. The psychology of knowledge, then, is a cognitive psychology, not an empirical psychology.

For Aristotle, the agent-intellect was a kind of light, making manifest what would otherwise be latent. As the sun makes apparent that which exists whether seen or not, so the agent-intellect makes actual that which remains only a potentiality. Thus, it is an interior light, illuminating particulars in such a way as to allow reason to discover their principle. For Aquinas, this interior light is the gift of a providential God by which human knowledge can reach the fundamental principles of things.²⁶ The abstractions made possible by this interior light are not (Platonically) removed from the world of matter (though they themselves are not material), but they reveal a nonsensory aspect of matter. We can be sure these features or principles are inherent in things, or else we could not derive the abstractions from the evidence of sense: *Abstrahentium non est mendacium* ("The abstraction is no lie!"). The connection between matter and principle or object and form is discovered, not invented, by the mind. As de Wulf noted in his analysis of the Thomistic theory of knowledge:

We perceive directly reality itself, and not our subjective modification of it. We perceive it thanks to a close collaboration between sense and intellect. . . . Truth is the correspondence between reality and mind.²⁷

Human knowledge, in human earthly life, is imperfect, and this is because human reason is imperfectly equipped to grasp the divine essence. Faith has been made available to men so that the imperfections of reason will not cause them to stray from God. However, faith and reason do not conflict and cannot conflict, since both seek the same truths:

Science and faith cannot be in the same subject and about the same object; but what is an object of science for one can be an object of faith for another.²⁸

Scholastic rationalism is of a limited sort. Reason can take us only so far in the search for truth. Even with the aid of faith, the rational mind cannot know all in this life. Not only are we all limited as a genus, but not every individual enjoys the same rational faculty as every other. All human beings possess the agent-intellect but not necessarily in the same degree.²⁹ There will be differences, therefore, in achievement and comprehension. Moreover, since reason's operations are performed on the data of experience, those whose experiences are limited (such as children) or distorted (as in the case of the sick) will have

an impoverished intellect.³⁰ During earthly life, which finds the soul united with the body, it is impossible for our intellect to understand anything actually except by turning to "phantasms," which are the mental representations arising from sensations. As Thomas Aquinas expresses the point "man is impelled in the consideration of intelligible things by being preoccupied with sensible things."³¹ These phantasms are the images that perception makes of external objects. The child, the delirious, and the enfeebled, all fail to record reality aptly and thus fail to understand. But even for them, there is an afterlife in which the soul no longer requires the senses, and in which truth no longer must be abstracted from sensible things.

In light of the foregoing, differences among individuals as regards their capacity for knowledge leads inescapably to governance by some and servility by others. Before the sin of Adam, we lived in a state of innocence. Even in this state, some would lead and others follow, but only by common consent; in a state of innocence, slavery is repugnant.³² However, ours is no longer a state of innocence. Through original sin and weakness of the will we fail in our duty either by failing to perceive duty or by failing to act once we have perceived it. In either case, the sin is a departure from the rule of reason.³³ It is the rule of reason that establishes the eternal law in the mind. As one may know of the sun through its rays, so, with respect to the eternal law, "every rational creature knows it according to some reflection, greater or less."³⁴ Those privileged to know it clearly must lead those who are less fortunate. The will of the prince is indeed the law of the land, but only insofar as the prince discharges the responsibilities for which the office was created.

In addition to advancing a general epistemological system that combined empirical and rational elements, the Scholastics also examined more specific psychological functions such as learning, memory, habit, emotion, and language. Throughout the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries the guiding maxim, "Nothing is in the intellect which was not first in the senses," remained, and to this extent Scholastic applied psychology was empirical. Medieval students relied on similarity and vividness to help their memory for facts³⁵ and domestic pets were trained by the disciplined dispensing of sweets and cuffs! There was also a more than a casual interest in dreams, at least as much as every other epoch has displayed. But more important than any of these to the future of a scientific psychology was the medieval discovery, although a limited one, of the experimental approach to nature. This approach was initiated by Grosseteste and developed by Duns Scotus and William of Ockham.

Experimental Science

[Robert] Grosseteste appears to have been the first medieval writer to recognize and deal with the two fundamental methodological prob-

lems of induction and experimental verification and falsification which arose when the Greek conception of geometrical demonstration was applied to the world of experience. He appears to have been the first to set out a systematic and coherent theory of experimental investigation and rational explanation by which the Greek geometrical method was turned into modern experimental science.³⁶

When we list the philosophical achievements of the twelfth century, we include high on the list the effective integration of rationalism and empiricism, of Aristotle's logic and Aristotle's experimentalism. In this connection, we must recall that Aristotle's principal failing as a scientist was rooted in an attachment to idealism inherited from Plato and never fully rejected, an attachment that led him to require a kind of rational ("final cause") justification even for the ordinary facts of science. It led him also to a model of scientific explanation that was demonstrative, logically structured, and formal. It was as a naturalist that he is found so carefully observing the habits and appearances of the animal kingdom, urging Alexander to order his troops to bring back specimens, reflecting on lunar eclipses, explaining why a greater variety of animals is found in Libya, etc. In these spheres he not only captured the spirit of modern science but did much to lay foundations for it.

Grosseteste and his colleagues at Oxford and, a little later, Albertus Magnus and others at Paris succeeded in joining these historically dissociated elements of the Aristotelian legacy. Aided by recent translations of Greek studies in optics and of Euclid's mathematical essays, they set out deliberately to establish scientific proofs through experimental procedures—in other words, to bring logical analysis to bear upon nature only after recording natural events with precision. This program can be viewed either as a natural extension of Aristotle's own program or as an improvement on it, but, in either case, it served as an anticipation of the more fully developed conceptions of scientific understanding that would flourish in the late Renaissance.

The religious orthodoxy of the twelfth and thirteenth centuries had a salutary effect upon these scientific enterprises. Peter Lombard had offered convincing arguments for finding God in His works, and this notion was a veritable theological directive. Even before Thomas Aquinas formally distinguished between the truths of science and those of faith, arguing that one did not conflict with the other, Peter Abailard (like Avicenna before him) had posited a dualistic psychology that placed perception and its objects exclusively in the material realm. Even more significantly, an orthodox believer such as Grosseteste had no doubt about the Final Cause, which is God, and therefore could examine efficient causes without fear of heresy. His credentials as an unrelenting enemy of Epicurean materialism were commendable. He never entertained the notion

that nature was only material and so he felt and perhaps was freer to explore those respects in which it was also material.

It was in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries also that translations of Greek medical works became widely available. The Hippocratic school and its descendants down to Galen were uniformly practical in their approach to disease. Diocles, the nutritionist, never paused to assess the logical structure according to which cucumbers from Antioch soothed the bowels. Nor was it necessary to analyze the syllogistic terms applicable to muscle, nerve, and artery. Greek medicine was observational, correlational, practical; in short, it was *clinical*, as medical practice is to today. It remained for the medieval scientists to recognize that the methods that advanced medicine were useful in any branch of inquiry, including, for example, optics, physics, and astronomy. Of course, the resulting factual knowledge could not be of scientific consequence unless it was (rationally) tied to a general theory. What was necessary, then, was to enter the observational domain with a hypothesis, to record events predicted by that hypothesis, and then to deduce the chain of effects that must take place if observation and hypothesis are properly compatible.

We can appreciate the novelty of approach and outlook in this age through two passages, one from Roger Bacon and the second from Duns Scotus. Here is Roger Bacon in his *Opus Majus*:

I now wish to unfold the principles of experimental science, since without experience nothing can be sufficiently known. For there are two modes of acquiring knowledge, namely by reasoning and experience. Reasoning draws a conclusion and makes us grant the conclusion, but does not make the conclusion certain, nor does it remove doubt so that the mind may rest on the intuition of truth, unless the mind discovers it by the path of experience. . . . Aristotle's statement then that proof is reasoning that causes us to know is to be understood with the proviso that the proof is accompanied by its appropriate experience, and is not to be understood of the bare proof. He therefore who wishes to rejoice without doubt in regard to the truths underlying phenomena must know how to devote himself to experiment.³⁷

We must not review the many actual experiments conducted by Roger Bacon in his attempt to confirm the value of this new science: one, for example, involved the use of a stone prism to separate sunlight into the spectrum. The freshness of his thought is apparent in the words themselves. Although not rejecting Aristotle's rationalistic approach to proof, he tempers it with the undeniable, immediate facts of controlled observation. Reason, the interior sense, works with perception (the external sense) and forges certain knowledge. Note that this is not the certain knowledge of the syllogism; that is, a purely logical certainty of the kind entailed by the Aristotelian notion of demonstration.

Rather, it is empirically certain knowledge, something that neither Plato nor Aristotle was willing to endorse with enthusiasm.

The same idea is advanced by Duns Scotus:

As for what is known by experience, I have this to say. Even though a person does not experience every single individual, but only a great many, nor does he experience them at all times, but only frequently, still he knows infallibly that it is always this way and holds for all instances. He knows this in virtue of this proposition reposing in his soul: "Whatever occurs in a great many instances by a cause that is not free, is the natural effect of that cause." This proposition is known to the intellect even if derived from erring senses.³⁸

Robert Grosseteste, Roger Bacon, and Duns Scotus, who made up the "Oxford school," had successfully begun to delimit a new approach to epistemology that would be made official by William of Ockham (1300–1349) and would secure for Ockham one of the more celebrated positions in the history of science. Scotus pleaded for the validity of empirical knowledge. Ockham went even further by reserving to observation the very basis on which any universal concept might be formed. In strict nominalist fashion, he argued that the universal is the name invented by the perceiver to represent that class of particulars learned by experience. In the absence of sensory commerce with particulars, no universal could be conceived. Logic will take us just so far in our quest for knowledge. At some point, we must temper or even abandon the formalisms of logic in favor of evident truths.

Ockham's razor, the maxim that has guided scientific explanation for six hundred years, was an instrument honed by many hands. Grosseteste, Thomas Aquinas, and Duns Scotus were as disinclined to "multiply causes unnecessarily" as was Ockham. Where he exceeded his predecessors was in examining more carefully the nature of the mind itself, in his attempt to assess the reality of universals and, for that matter, particulars. It is not surprising that Renaissance scholars would be able to identify more readily with the writings of Ockham, not because Ockhamism was liberally heretical, but because it was fundamentally psychological.

Ockham's Psychological Synthesis

Ockham was more deliberately psychological in his approach than any of his Scholastic predecessors or contemporaries. Both Thomas Aquinas and Duns Scotus, as well as Albertus Magnus, had addressed the issue of human reason and had posited psychological principles of perception, memory, and the will. Their efforts, however, were pre-theoretical and were never far removed from the larger religious context which was their central concern. Ockham, on the

contrary, proposed specific psychological principles in a rigorously theoretical manner, and brought these principles to bear upon religious questions. Where others had taken the truths of theology as the starting point in their exploration of human nature, Ockham chose to employ human psychological dispositions in an attempt to discern the way in which theological conceptions came into being. His approach is not revealed in any single treatise on psychology proper but suffuses the entire range of his scholarship.

Oswald Fuchs has prepared a most useful compilation of Ockham's psychology, drawn from his major works.³⁹ At the core of Ockham's theories is the concept of *habit* (*habitus*) which, in the Latin of Ockham (and in the technical, philosophical Latin of the Romans as well), is understood as an acquired disposition, a perfected state or condition. It represents a qualitative change in the individual such that one is now able to do easily, or perceive readily, or behave effortlessly where, initially, these acts and experiences were difficult or incomplete.

Since the habit disposes the individual to conduct of a certain sort, it must either be present as a condition of birth or it must be acquired. As dissatisfied with the Platonic solution given in the *Meno* as was Aristotle, Ockham argues that habits must be acquired, since fundamentally they are dispositions toward specific objects. We cannot be born with the habit of dressing neatly, since nothing in our intrauterine life is able to anticipate fashion. Now, if our commonest habits require experience and practice, is there any reason to assume that any habit results from something different? Ockham's answer is a resounding *No*: All our habits are the results of experience; none is innate, including our moral habits or "virtues." Although Aristotle's associationistic theory of learning was similarly empirical, as is shown most clearly in his description of the new-born soul as a *tabula nuda* in his *Nicomachean Ethics*, Book III) and also in his *Posterior Analytics*, in which he argues that we know principles through experience and practice (Book II, 100a), Aristotle is not entirely consistent on the point. In the *Categories*, habit is rendered as essentially changeless (8a-9b), and in the *Metaphysics* habits of a certain sort are viewed as inherent (Book V, 1022b). Thus, Ockham is not to be judged merely as an Aristotelian. His theory is far less compromising in its empiricism. It is also more specific in distinguishing between instincts and similar physiological dispositions and habits that are intellectual, gradual in their appearance, and changeable through disuse or conflict.

Consistent with his nominalist position on the question of universals, Ockham insisted that the habit conduces to a given act, is disposed to particular objects, and is strengthened by the specific exercise of the act of which it is the habit. However, the mind, not nature, can (and does) come to create general categories in which are included acts and objects of a perceptibly similar nature. By a process of abstraction (or in modern parlance, what behaviorists might refer to as "stimulus generalization"), the mind will relate habitually to

a number of objects that resemble each other. Cautiously, Ockham avoids speculating on how this is done, describing the process only as *natura occulta*, a process of a hidden or secret nature. There is no universal outside the mind (*extra animam*), but one produced by the mind after frequent experience.

Ockham also discoursed on the passions and appetites, which, through their association with habits, motivate behavior of an appetitive variety. While insisting that some acts of the will are moral, Ockham argued that these are subjectively moral in that they are acts of the will; that is, moral acts, like other habits, are acquired and therefore cannot be by necessity. Any absoluteness possessed by them must derive from God, not from our experiences.

William of Ockham is a fitting conclusion to the Scholastic period. His emphasis on human psychology serves as an introduction to the Renaissance, as does his focus on experience, experiment, and natural causation. Dante died in 1321, Ockham in 1349. Dante was, in all symbolic respects, the last spokesman for the distinctively romantic tone of medieval life, a life in which allegory was real, fact suspect, and nature threatening. Ockham, more than symbolically, is one of the first spokesmen of the coming age, an age of confidence, individualism, and grandness coexisting with "natural magic," witch-hunts, superstition, and attempts to forge a scientific worldview.

Chivalry, Honor, and the Ideal Life

Of the various institutions, beliefs, and practices that serve to separate the medieval epoch from other historic periods, none is as unique as chivalry. It is the embodiment of the popular psychology of the Middle Ages in the way that Scholasticism is the embodiment of the academic psychology of the period. And, like Scholasticism, chivalry resists easy classification. We begin to understand it as an idea only by recognizing how readily the medieval mind blended fact and metaphor so completely as to create a cognitive reality that was nearly otherworldly. In *The Waning of the Middle Ages*, Professor Huizinga has described this feature of the medieval mind thus:

The conception of chivalry as a sublime form of secular life might be defined as an aesthetic ideal assuming the appearance of an ethical ideal. Heroic fancy and romantic sentiment form its basis. But medieval thought did not permit ideal forms of noble life, independent of religion. For this reason, piety and virtue have to be the essence of a knight's life. . . . The . . . revival of the splendor of chivalry that we find everywhere in European courts after 1300 is already connected with the Renaissance by a real link. It is a naive prelude to it.⁴⁰

Committed with as much earnestness as the Scholastics to the idea of natural order, but with far less criticality, the medieval citizen perceived the world to be a set of established and immutable arrangements, arrangements of a hierar-

chic order with the Church supreme, its safety and prosperity in the hands of knights and noblemen. It made no difference whether the commoner was a plain farmer, a simple merchant, or a cultivated burgher. Unless one served God directly as a cleric or a knight, one's position was of diminished significance. Even as the lowest economic classes loomed in real importance, the members of these clerical and aristocratic classes refused to acknowledge the growth of their power. Riveted in the mind was the notion of eternal order, social level, and God's will animating both.

We need not pause to criticize here. We can have sympathy or scorn, for example, for the hopeless attempts to reclaim Jerusalem, the "Holy Sepulchre," at a time when the Balkans were on the verge of falling to the Turks, or for the oddly macabre tournaments in which life and limb were sacrificed in the name of honor. These are merely symptoms or correlates of a deeper set of values and a more fundamental perceptual bias:

All realism, in the medieval sense, leads to anthropomorphism. Having attributed a real existence to an idea, the mind wants to see this idea alive, and can only effect this by personifying it. In this way, allegory is born. It is not the same thing as symbolism. Symbolism expresses a mysterious connection between two ideas, allegory gives a visible form to the conception of such a connection. . . . Embracing all nature and all history, symbolism gave a conception of the world, of a still more rigorous unity than that which modern science can offer. Symbolism's image of the world is distinguished by impeccable order, architectonic structure, hierarchic subordination.⁴¹

In parallel fashion, the Scholastic philosophers and the public at large interpreted nature according to a great scheme, with each piece fitting its intended slot, each act serving an ultimate purpose, each event fulfilling the prophesy of the symbol. The two abiding conditions of the human coil, love and death, were dressed in rituals of unimaginable complexity and formality. Pure sensuality, which has never vanished in any epoch, was disguised by the heavy curtain of courtly love that required honor before pleasure: that is, it required suffering and sacrifice as conditions for pleasure. In literature, the allegory reigned, notably in the influential *Roman de la Rose*, in which the union of lovers is preceded and attended by a veritable legion of virtues, saints, demons, and coordinators—right up to and including the moment at which the rose is finally plucked.

The chivalric ideal represented and preserved the medieval belief in man as divine creation in order to serve specific and different functions. Classes, since they existed, were intended to exist for the same reason that the number "7," chosen by God for the planets, was sacred. The world itself is worth noting only as a symbol or metaphor of God's work, and, when noting it correctly, one

must find in it order, symbol, and the divine. Faith is the light; reason the guide; suffering, honor, and humility the way. With the pope as Plato's philosopher-king, with the knights as his guardians, and with a world in which symbols enjoy the ultimate reality of the Ideas, the medieval mind created a republic where, in fact, a civilization was crumbling.

In observing the parallel development of a Scholastic theory of conduct and the chivalric ideal, we do not mean to suggest that the latter was a conscious product of the former. Whatever praise might be heaped on the knight-errant, it surely would not include an award for scholarship. Rather, we describe the development as parallel, in that Scholasticism and chivalry both reflect the same features of the High Middle Ages but in different ways. The citizen recognized distinct classes, each with distinct responsibilities. Thomas Aquinas set forth these distinctions more formally:

For everything is for the sake of its operation, since operation is the ultimate perfection of a thing.⁴²

However, not only do species differ in their inclinations, owing to a different plan God has for them, but individuals also differ from other members of the same species, "and a sign of this is that they are not the same in all, but differ in different subjects."⁴³ It was not necessary for the nobles of the thirteenth century to read the *Summa Contra Gentiles* in order to learn of their own special obligations, nor was it necessary for Thomas Aquinas to study the social arrangements of the court in order to discern that God has intended each individual, uniquely, to participate in the divine adventure. We may ask, however, in the light of this encompassing perspective, how the High Middle Ages were saved from the doleful form of Stoicism that engulfed Rome in the late stages of the empire? In some respects, of course, the medieval perspective must be judged as Stoical. Every major Christian spokesman agreed that the universe and all its contents were under the influence of God's gaze and owed their existence and their destiny to His will. Except for the introduction of a personal and knowable creator, the medieval scholars in this respect are indistinguishable from several of the followers of Zeno. For that matter, they are not far removed from the rationalist astronomers of the seventeenth century or any radical determinist of our own time. But the inclusion of a personal and a knowable God makes a great difference here, a difference great enough to call for restraint in assessing the Stoic elements in medieval thought. For the medieval Christian, God has endowed human beings (and only such beings) with free will, thereby permitting autonomy and indeterminacy in human affairs. The price we pay for the freedom is, of course, responsibility. We can be said to sin only because we can be said to choose. Our actions are worthy of praise or blame only to the extent that they are voluntary. Scholasticism grants to animals only an instinctive disposition to move toward or away from objects

depending on which of the animal's appetites are excited by the stimulus: animals, on the Scholastic account, are reflexive but not reflective. Man, as a rational creature, can control his appetites and thereby resist actions. Both human and animal actions occur according to a principle that exists within them; but, whereas the animal has only the appetitive principle, humans have, in addition, the intellectual principle.⁴⁴ Accordingly, when we sin it is not because the will has taken control of reason but because the latter has failed to note the evil that attaches to an otherwise pleasurable sensation.⁴⁵ This is entirely consistent with Socrates' insistence that actions committed to ignorance are involuntary. Thus, to the extent that we are rational, our will seeks the good, unless misled by sensation. To the extent that we reject reason, we may free ourselves from blame but only at the forfeiture of all that attaches to being human.

Scholastic Psychology and Its Implications

The two and a half centuries beginning in 1100 were among the most inventive in Western history. Not only did scholars such as Roger Bacon, Robert Grosseteste, Duns Scotus, and William of Ockham define and promote the experimental approach to knowledge, but even heads of state shared in the new learning. Prominent in the latter category was Frederick II, Holy Roman Emperor and King of Sicily (1194–1250). It was this “Renaissance man” who addressed philosophical and scientific questions to scholars throughout the realm and to the Arabs as well. It was he who, putting philosophy and religion aside, experimented with predatory birds, proving their ability to locate prey by smell by blindfolding them. It is said that he reared children in stark silence to determine whether Hebrew was the universal innate language. He also is said to have tagged fish and returned them to the lake to determine their longevity.⁴⁶

Frederick II was not common in these respects among the political leaders of his time—in what age would such a king be common?—but he does appear in the earliest chapter of a new kind of learning, scientific learning. He did not reject the Scholastic system, nor did the Renaissance that followed in any but the most carping respects. Rather, he was a product of Scholasticism, as were Grosseteste, Scotus, and Ockham. Scholasticism was not a single body of truths or a rigid set of methods. It was not a cult or a version of Christianity. It was a movement and, as such, was as diverse as the other isms which fill the canvas of intellectual history.

In according to human life a central position in the creation, Scholasticism defended this priority on grounds as psychological as they were theological: man was the animal with free will, reason, and intellect; man was made in the divine image; man was born in sin and ever on the edge of error; and man, like God, was to be known by his works. These themes would be expanded and secularized over the next two hundred years and would take the form of Re-

naissance humanism. The chivalric ideal would be translated into the concept of human dignity. Experimentalism, under heavy pressures in a very practical world but one still spiritual in tone, would appear at first as natural magic, then as natural science. As children of the Divine, human beings would come to challenge the authority of pope and king alike. It was not for the Middle Ages to achieve these levels. Instead, it set the stage. As a period simultaneously discovering experimental science and the special place of human reason in the great scheme, the Middle Ages brought psychology closer to its modern expression by removing it further from its transcendental heritage. That the Scholastics did not reinvent modern psychology is to be understood in terms of their unwillingness to take the decisive step taken earlier by the Hellenic and Hellenistic Greeks: the step of viewing mind as object. The Renaissance fared no better in this respect. In addition, the Scholastics were concerned more with systematizing than with manipulating nature. As a result, they succeeded in recognizing the systematic character of experimental science but not in initiating actual experimental programs. They were, in this regard, more aloof than the Greeks, and they paid the same price: a somewhat impoverished technology.

Their fleeting tilts with empiricism aside, they were rationalists to the core; that is, a generally impractical sort. But the age they forged, unlike so many in history, commands more respect the more we learn about it. It is a measure of the intellectual originality of the Scholastics that we identify the "modern" period of scientific and philosophical inquiry with an age (the seventeenth century) that devoted itself to refutations of Scholastic arguments. It is more than curious, for example, that Newton, Galileo, Descartes, Hartley, Hobbes, Francis Bacon, and John Locke either explicitly cite Scholastic sources or offer their own theories against the background of Scholastic thought.

The Scholastic record speaks for itself, and can mount a formidable defense of at least the following claims: that the period from 1150 to 1300 hosted more original and significant contributions to logic than any comparable period since Greek antiquity; and that these contributions were not reviewed and extended until the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. Scholarship in psychology in the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries came closer to the sorts of issues that would define modern psychology than did any until late in the eighteenth century. Specifically, the Scholastic analyses of the competing claims of nativism and environmentalism, sensationism and conceptualism, free will and deterministic behaviorism, mind-body materialism and dualism, and individualism and social determinism were sophisticated, deep, suggestive, and mature by the best standards of assessment that we have. The Scholastics recognized more fully than most schools except the Socratic the need for linguistic analysis as the first step in the evaluation of philosophical arguments. More completely than Aristotle, the Scholastics examined rival philosophies of science and

sought to establish the respective functions to be served by observation, logic, and hypothesis. That so much of the scholarship of the period was devoted to theological details no longer troubling to the modern imagination simply reflects what they took to be the higher values—future historians will, perhaps, wonder why so much of our own scholarship is devoted to mechanical details. But in poring over their problems, they made lasting contributions to ethics, politics, law, and (even if negatively) science. This much is now in the record. Ours is not yet complete.

Notes

1. An excellent analysis of the legal and moral obligations existing between vassal and lord is provided in Marc Bloch, *Feudal Society*, University of Chicago Press, 1961, Ch. XIV. Translations of several original documents of interests appear in *The Records of Medieval Europe*, ed. Carolly Erickson, Doubleday, Garden City, N.Y., 1971, pp. 161–163. See also R. W. Southern, *The Making of the Middle Ages*, Yale University Press, New Haven, 1959.

2. Southern, *Middle Ages*, p. 104.

3. Henri Pirenne, *Medieval Cities: Their Origins and the Revival of Trade*, translated by Frank D. Halsey, Princeton University Press, Princeton, 1952.

4. *Ibid.*, p. 25.

5. Cited in *Studies in Human Time* by Georges Poulet, Johns Hopkins Press, Baltimore, 1956, p. 10. Professor Poulet has provided a most valuable study of the manner in which different epochs conceived of time and how these varied conceptions are revealed in the literary works of the periods.

6. Bloch, *Feudal Society*, pp. 73, 75.

7. Cited in Peter Munz, *Life in the Age of Charlemagne*, Capricorn Books, New York, 1971, p. 119.

8. *Ibid.*, p. 122.

9. *The Canticle of the Sun*, by St. Francis of Assisi, in *The Writings of St. Francis of Assisi*, translated by Fr. P. Robinson, Dolphin Press, Philadelphia, 1906.

10. Munz, *Age of Charlemagne*.

11. The trivium, which comprised all of the medieval curriculum, was Alcuin's invention.

12. The most authoritative and seminal study of the nascent features of the period remains Charles Homer Haskins, *The Renaissance of the Twelfth Century*, Harvard University Press, Cambridge, 1927.

13. St. Augustine, *De Trinitate*, Book XI, translated by Whitney Oates, Random House, New York, 1948.

14. Haskins, *Renaissance of the Twelfth Century*, p. 14.

15. Anders Pilz, *The World of Medieval Learning*, translated by David Jones. Basil Blackwell, London, 1981, p. 56.

16. Maurice de Wulf, *An Introduction to Scholastic Philosophy*, Dover edition, 1956, p. 125).

17. John Scotus Eriugena, *De Divisione Naturae*, Book 4, Chs. 7–9. A good trans-

lation can be found in *Selections from Medieval Philosophers*, Vol. I, edited by Richard McKeon, Scribner, New York, 1929.

18. St. Anselm, *Dialogus de Veritate*, in McKeon, *Selections*.

19. St. Anselm's ontological argument is presented and discussed in *The Ontological Argument*, introduction by Alvin Planting, edited by Richard Taylor, Doubleday, Anchor Books, Garden City, N.Y., 1965.

20. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologica*, Question 75, Part I. All references to the work of Thomas Aquinas are based on the translations of Anton Pegis in the Random House edition of the *Basic Writings of Thomas Aquinas*.

21. *Ibid.*, Question 75, Article 6.

22. *Ibid.*, Question 76, Article 5.

23. *Ibid.*, Question 77, Article 5.

24. *Ibid.*, Question 77, Article 8.

25. *Ibid.*, Question 79, Article 3.

26. *Ibid.*, Question 79, Article 4.

27. de Wulf, *An Introduction*, p. 45.

28. Aquinas, *Summa Theologica*, Question 2, Article 4.

29. *Ibid.*, Question 79, Article 6.

30. *Ibid.*, Question 101, Article 2.

31. *Ibid.*, Question 84, Article 7; Question 94, Article 1.

32. *Ibid.*, Question 96, Article 4.

33. *Ibid.*, Question 73, Article 7.

34. *Ibid.*, Question 93, Article 2.

35. For an excellent and intriguing review of the techniques employed over the ages to improve memory see Frances A. Yates, *The Art of Memory*, University of Chicago Press, 1966.

36. A. C. Crombie, *Grosseteste and Experimental Science*, Clarendon Press, Oxford, 1953, pp. 10–11.

37. Roger Bacon, *Opus Majus*, Vol. II, Pt. VI, Ch. 1, translated by Robert Belle Burke, University of Pennsylvania Press, Philadelphia, 1928.

38. John Duns Scotus, *Concerning Human Understanding*, in *Philosophical Writings*, translated by Allan Wolter, Thomas Nelson and Sons, London, 1962.

39. Oswald Fuchs, *The Psychology of Habit According to William of Ockham*, The Franciscan Institute, St. Bonaventure, N.Y., 1952.

40. Johan Huizinga, *The Waning of the Middle Ages*, Doubleday, Garden City, N.Y., pp. 69–71.

41. *Ibid.*, p. 205.

42. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Contra Gentiles*, translated by Anton Pegis, in the *Basic Writings of Thomas Aquinas*, Ch. CXIII, p. 223.

43. *Ibid.*

44. Aquinas, *Summa Theologica*, Question 6, Article 2.

45. *Ibid.*, Question 6, Article 4.

46. An excellent discussion of science in the Court of Frederick II is presented by Charles Homer Haskins in *Studies in the History of Medieval Science*, Frederick Ungar, New York, 1924, Chs. 12–15.

6

Nature and Spirit in the Renaissance

Was There a Renaissance?

Abrupt historical transitions exist far more frequently in the historian's mind than in the world of events. At the same time, we have observed that dramatic alterations in perspective do occur and that these have occasionally taken place on a relatively large scale. Two ready illustrations are to be found between the Augustan period of Rome and the seventh century, and between the Homeric period of Greek history and the Age of Pericles. A more recent, equally vivid change in perspective occurred in far less time: that between the early empire of Charlemagne and the philosophical revival of the twelfth century.

In comparing the members of any one of these apposed pairs, one is struck by the degree and number of differences in institutions, social organizations, political processes, aesthetic productions, and philosophical and psychological inclinations. This makes it all the more surprising that most general histories focus on the Renaissance and accord to it a status rare in the annals of historical analysis. It is a focus or emphasis that tempts the more critical reader or writer to overcompensate by denying anything original to the period. But this is a compensation well worth avoiding. Undoubtedly the Renaissance that flowered in Florence in the fifteenth century and spread throughout Europe by the sixteenth is a period of change, and the changes it brought either touched or completely altered the full range of existing social and political institutions. The medieval town gave way to the Renaissance city. Chivalry disappeared and patronage took its place. The scholarship of devotion gradually relinquished first place to humanistic studies and halting steps toward the natural sciences. The full partnership of Church and State became more competitive, occasionally combative. Secular authority grew, and economics came to challenge theology as the State's first science.

When scholars and aesthetes of the nineteenth century invented the term,